

More than just browsers

Is the death of the browser imminent? We don't know yet, but a recent study by Nielsen//NetRatings, a market research company in the US, showed that 76 per cent of Americans use non-browser based applications such as media players, instant messengers and file-sharing applications to access the Internet.



The study showed that the total unique audience using non-browser applications reached 106 million during November 2003. The top applications online are Windows Media Player (34 per cent of the active user base), AOL Instant Messenger (20 per cent), Real Player (20 per cent), MSN Messenger (19 per cent), Yahoo! Messenger (12 per cent). The study also revealed that MSN.com was the most visited site during the same period.

snapshot

India has **42 million** fixed telephone lines and **28.2 million** mobile phones—over **70 million** phone subscribers

Source: TRAI

Counterfeiting currency detector

The latest digital imaging version of the cat and mouse game involves the almost ubiquitous Adobe Photoshop, and our everyday paper currency. It all began with Photoshop's latest version Creativity Suite including a 'counterfeit deterrence system' that prevents users from accessing images of currency. When this system detects an attempt at accessing currency images, it aborts the operation by displaying a warning, and taking the user to www.rules-foruse.org, a Web site that gives information on international counterfeiting laws. The description of Indian rules on this Web site is, "Under Construction".

But with users, it is sometimes just commonsense that lets them overcome the most difficult of problems, even if they are illegal. For instance, in this case, one can copy the image into some other program, and paste it in a new file in Photoshop. Another

way is to open and save in an earlier version of Photoshop, and then open it with Photoshop CS. Yet another way is to invoke Photoshop from some other Adobe application, and scan currency images in pieces, and assemble them in Photoshop.



Adobe

said they have been working with central banks for several years, and have just incorporated this piece of software developed by The Central Bank Counterfeit Deterrence Group. The code is so secret that even Adobe doesn't know it! Further, Adobe said that it hasn't made the system "bullet-proof" because that would affect the productivity of the users.

World's first in-flight WiFi connectivity

The mile-high club just got a whole new meaning—Emirates airlines will soon offer an in-flight wireless laptop service for e-mail and SMS. Called Tenzing Service after the company they collaborating with (Tenzing Communications of Seattle, USA), the service lets passengers connect to the service using their laptops,

with little or no additional configuration.

This will be the world's first deployment of WiFi connectivity for laptops on regularly-scheduled commercial flights. The Airbus A340-500 will be the first aircraft with a wireless LAN for passengers. The service will be launched in the first quarter of 2004, on all of Emirates' new Airbus A340-500s.



Spam

Not the Real McCoy

Delhi High Court judge RC Chopra has ordered Indian firm McCoy InfoSystems to stop the transmission of unsolicited e-mail to any VSNL user. The judgement was in response to a case filed by Tata Sons Ltd, and Panatone Finwest Ltd, subsidiaries that own a large stake in VSNL. Since existing Indian laws do not offer legal recourse against spam, Tata Sons argued on the basis of trespassing and nuisance laws. In the end, a historic judgment was handed down, banning McCoy from using VSNL's resources.

Mobile wonders

The Financial Express reports that Indian advertising agency Ogilvy & Mather Interactive (O&M) is now looking at mobile phones as an avenue to help marketers build bonds, and using the phones as a customer response device. While this makes sense for solicited advertisements, it's also possible that fly-by-night operators may spam Indian cell phone users.

Join the fight

To counter the menace of spam, traditional (wired) ISPs and new-age wireless infrastructure providers have joined hands as the ISP Messaging Anti-abuse Working Group. The group—stalwart service providers such as Bell South, Bell Canada, Cox, Internet Initiative Japan and Openwave—have decided to jointly develop methods to shut down spammers before they flood networks. The group intends to set up a shared code of conduct and create best practices, to prevent spam, virii and other undesirables.



■ SuSE and Red Hat Linux offer to indemnify customers against charges of copyright violations ■ Soon-to-be launched Nintendo DS will come with dual, side-by-side screens